

# **Interview Essentials: Achieve Interview Success**

Slides from: Engineering Career Resource Center  
Presented by: David Wentzloff, Sept 6, 2024

# Key Points

- Goals of the interview
- Types of interviews
- Interview preparation tips
- Interview modes
- Interview follow-up
- Tips & Resources







It's all about the FIT

# Employer Interview Goals

## Can you do the job?

- Do you have the skills, knowledge and abilities required to perform the job?

## What is your motivation to do the job?

- Do your interests align with the position and the company?

## Will you do the job well within their organization?

- Are your values aligned with the company values?
- Do you approach your work in a way that is consistent with the company culture and operations?



# Candidate Interview Goals

Provide evidence that you can do the job

- Demonstrate skills, knowledge, and abilities

Be clear in your stories, help them understand how your work style matches their organization

- Are you collaborative, results oriented, innovative, creative, analytical, etc.

Be curious about the role and specific about your interest in working for the organization

- Ask thoughtful questions

Make a connection

- People hire candidates they feel they can work with

# Common Types of Interviews

**Technical Interview** – Interview style to assess the technical knowledge, skills and abilities of a candidate as it relates to specific job

**Case Interview** – A ‘real life’ challenging scenario that is presented to a candidate to assess their logic, reasoning and problem-solving abilities

**Behavioral Interview** – Technique to evaluate candidate’s past behavior in different situations in order to predict their future performance

# The Technical Interview

## Emphasizes problem solving and job specific knowledge

- Likely related to the type of work you will be doing
  - General questions regarding math problems or brain teaser
  - Coding Assessment or White-boarding Exercise
  - Design Presentation

## When answering technical interview questions

- Think out loud, explain your thought process and actions
  - Ask clarifying questions if needed
  - Use the tools provided (i.e. whiteboard)

## Acknowledge what you don't know and offer what you do

# The Technical Interview

## Some additional tips

- Study – start with your exam cheat sheets (i.e. 2 pages, front & back)
- It's not always about getting the right answer. Rather how you approach a problem.
- Think out loud – interviewer can't assess your approach if you sit there silent



# The Case Interview

Most often used by consulting companies to assess your thought process. Evaluates how you 'think on your feet', how you cope with ambiguity, and how well you communicate

## Analyze a 'real life' business question or scenario:

FashionCo, a player in the women's fashion market has been in the industry for a long time, but has experienced declining revenues each year for the past five years.

FashionCo wants to understand:

- What is causing this decline?
- What can the organization do to drive revenue?

FashionCo will have a management meeting at the end of the week, and the CEO wants a recommendation from Bain on how to proceed.

## Preparation Resources:

- <https://www.mckinsey.com/careers/interviewing>
- <https://careers.bcg.com/case-interview-preparation>
- <https://www.bain.com/careers/interview-prep/case-interview/>

# Example

Circa 1997 Wentzloff was interviewing at ANS in Ann Arbor and was asked the following:

Give me directions from your apartment to the nearest gas station. Be as detailed as possible.

ANS managed internet access hardware across the US.

Companies like AOL sub-contracted to them.

I was applying for a position on their technical support team.

Why would they ask a question like this?

# Behavioral Interviews

## Story Based Questions + Responses

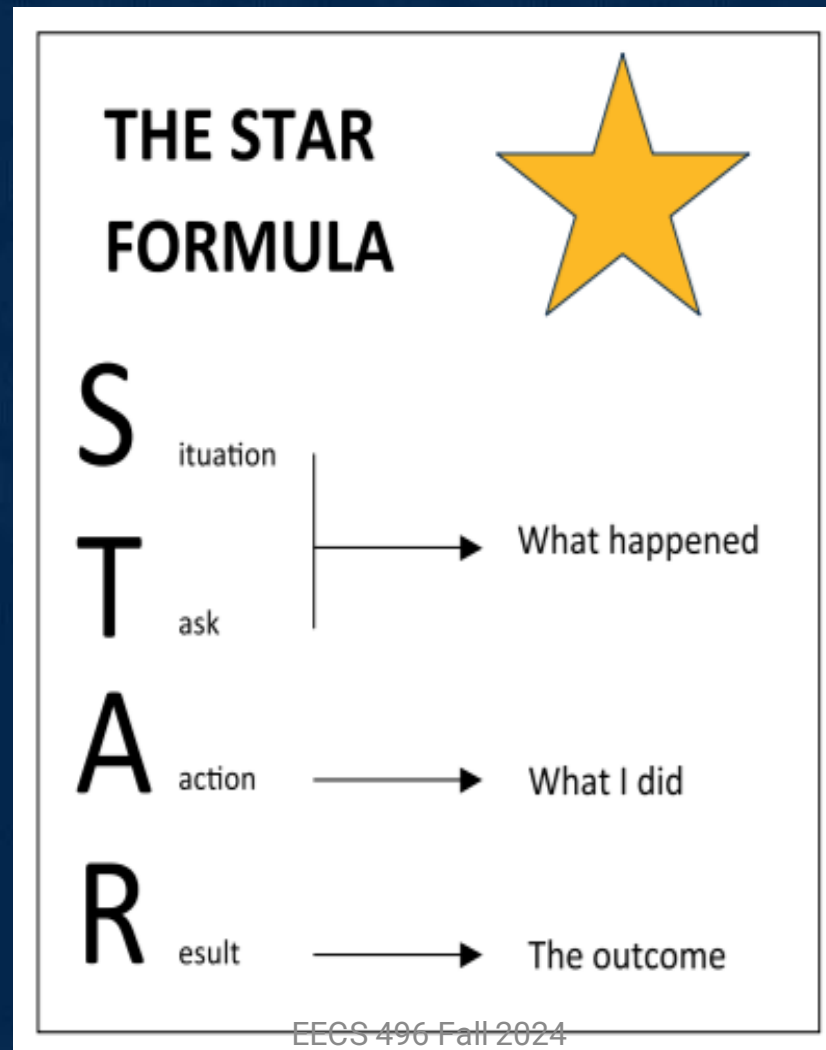
- Tell me about a time when...
- Describe a situation where...
- Give me an example of ...

## Theme Based Questions

- Problem Solving
- Leadership
- Project Management
- Teamwork
- Adaptability
- Time Management
- Communication

## Structured Responses are Essential

# Behavioral Interview Answers Formula for Success

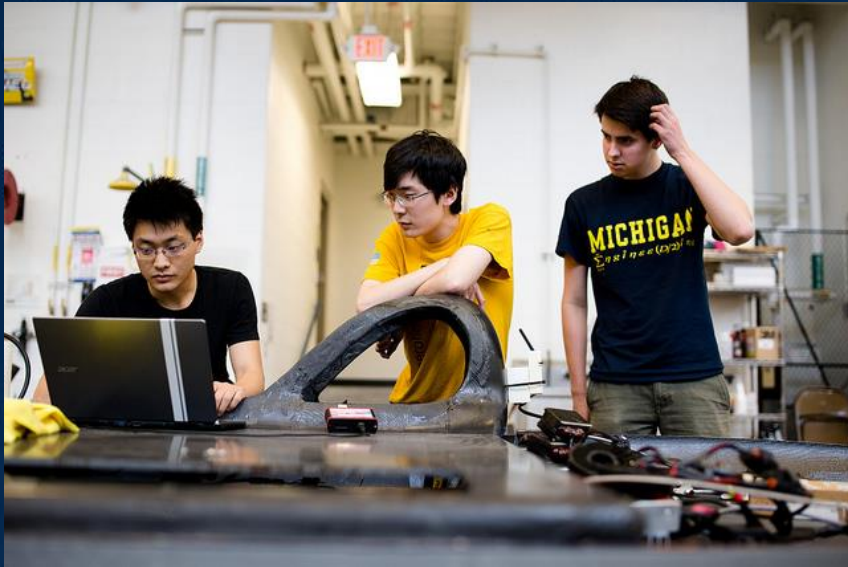




# Q: Describe a time you had a conflict with a teammate on a project. What did you do?

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| <p>During my Intro Java class (CS) last semester, we were assigned a partner project at the end of term, which would serve as our final exam.</p> <p>The assignment was open ended. Basically, we were asked to take what we learned in class and create something cool.</p> <p>The basic parameters required us to incorporate networking (2 computers talking) and a database (place to store data).</p> <p>We were given one month to complete the assignment, at which time our project would be evaluated by our peers and professor during the final presentation.</p> | <p>We decided to design a multiplayer fantasy football game simulator. Players would determine the plays and interact with opponents remotely.</p> <p>The code was complex and there were a lot of features we wanted to include. Mid-way through, we realized time was running short and we had to prioritize our features.</p> <p>We met to discuss our priorities and it became clear that we didn't agree.</p> <p>My partner wanted to focus on the graphic elements to make the game look really good for a higher peer evaluation.</p> <p>I wanted to focus on more complex code to demonstrate coding skills for a higher professor evaluation.</p> | <p>After losing some time debating our positions, I suggested that we go through each feature one by one, and assign a point value to estimate its impact on our final grade, and then devote time to the features with the greatest impact, working through as many as we could until time ran out.</p> <p>My partner agreed.</p> <p>We agreed that the more visually appealing features were likely to have higher value. So we focused first on the team logos and player pictures.</p> <p>Then we incorporated more advanced coding to give players more play options.</p> <p>Ultimately we were both satisfied with our end product.</p> | <p>The final game included a player information window with multiple images (photo, logo, etc.) and gave players more play types.</p> <p>We presented a 10 minute demonstration to our class.</p> <p>The game was evaluated by our professor and approximately 100 students.</p> <p>We received high marks for both the visual appeal and the coding complexity, earning an A on the project.</p> <p>Through this experience, I learned the value of addressing conflict early, and developing a way to ensure that everyone's concerns are addressed as projects progress. This experience has made me a more collaborative teammate.</p> |

# Employer Advice: Be Specific!



“Some students need to work on citing specific examples. One especially good thing to have is an example of a creative or innovative design/process developed.”

– *Ford Recruiter*



“Be sure to give specific examples versus theoretical situations. Focus on what you did to resolve the issues.”

– *Cummins Recruiter*

# Prepare for the Interview

## Research the company and industry

- Review the job description & identify connections between the job and your skills, knowledge, and abilities

## Prepare for common questions

- Tell me about yourself and why are you interested in this position?
- What are your strengths and weaknesses?

## Prepare 5 – 10 success stories

- Potential themes: teamwork, leadership, problem solving, goal setting + achievement, overcoming challenges, time management, etc...

## Prepare questions for your interviewer

- What do you need to know to better understand the role, the process and possible transition. When can I expect to hear back?

## Salary research – Salary Information Resources:

- ECRC Major Information Sheets, ECRC Salary Website (Tableau dashboard), O\*NET, Salary.com, Glassdoor, etc.

# Plan For Your Introduction

## “Tell me about yourself”

### What to Consider

#### Who are you

- Educational background (i.e. degree level, major, year)

#### Recent, relevant, experiences

- Select 1 or 2 relevant experiences to share that demonstrate relevant skills to the employer

#### Career related inspirations, motivations, or aspirations

- Connect your experiences to the employer
- Share specific interest in employer and/or position

# Asking Questions During the Interview

## “Do you have any questions for me?”

### Clarifying Questions

- Would I likely lead the research portion of the engineering project?

### Research Based

- While preparing for our discussion today I read that ... can you tell me more about that?

### Conversational

- Earlier you mentioned...what more can you tell me about that?

### Procedural

- What is your anticipated timeline for the rest of the selection and hiring process?

### Tips

- Be intentional – what do you really want to know
- Consider your audience – who might be best to provide the answer
- Avoid asking multiple questions at one time



# Determine Your Market Value

*What is a competitive base salary in your field/type of work?*

- Do your research – early on in your job search
- Utilize reliable resources to find multiple data points to help identify trends among salary information you are gathering

## Salary Information Resources

### ECRC Resources

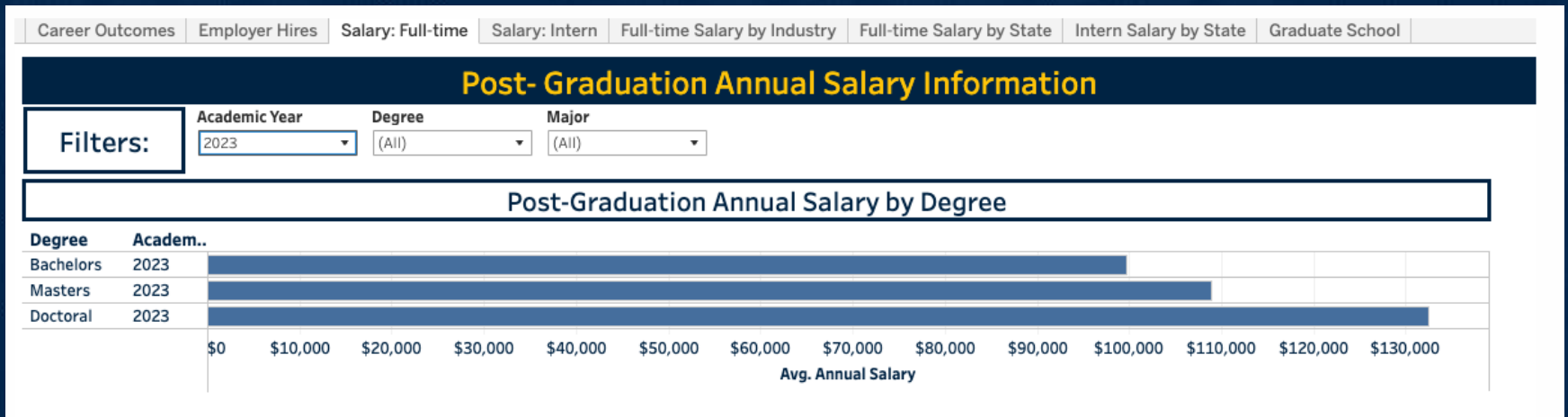
- ECRC Salary Website
  - Tableau dashboard with full-time + Industry Salaries

### Additional Resources

- O\*NET (Dept. of Labor)
- Salary.com
- Glassdoor

*What your friends say is not necessarily research – Be careful with 2<sup>nd</sup> hand information*

# Michigan Engineering's Salary Dashboard



<https://career.engin.umich.edu/michigan-engineering-student-salary-information/>

# Some Interviewing Advice

If on-site, use your lunch/dinner interviews with team members

- Are they collegial?
- Do they seem like they would be fun to work with?
- Do not drink!
- Listen for conflicts, doubts about products. Are they “bought in”?
- Ask about promotions, the company culture, etc.

# Illegal Interview Questions

It is illegal to ask a candidate questions about their:

- Birthplace or country of origin. Citizenship is grey area
- Disability
- Gender/sex or sexual orientation
- Marital status, family, family plans, or pregnancy
- Race or ethnicity
- Religion
- Age is a grey area

You can share if you want. But they can't ask.

# Modes of Interviews

- Phone Interview
- Virtual/Video Interview
- In Person or On-site Interview
- Assessments – skill or personality based





## Phone Interviews

- Create a sense of formality
  - Formal attire, good posture, etc...
- Be aware of your tone - smile
- Expect pauses
- Feel free to use notes, but don't shuffle papers
- Find a quiet interview space



## Virtual Interviews

- Test your technology before the interview
- Be aware of your setting – eliminate distractions for you and your interviewer
- Dress professionally & smile
- Look into the camera

# Example

Circa 2017 Wentzloff was conducting Zoom interviews to pre-screen applicants for a position

I had a standard set of questions that I asked every candidate

So I could more easily compare their qualifications.

Q's were a combo of behavioral and technical.

I started with “how much do you know about [company/position]”?

I let them know ahead of time this would be a video call

Most dressed biz-casual, were at a desk, and in a quiet place

One stood out, but not in a good way...

# In-Person/On-site Interview

## Know where you are going

- Plan for travel time and arrive early

## Dress professionally & maintain good posture

## In a professional folder or portfolio bring:

- Extra resumes, pen & notepad and a copy of the job posting
- TAKE NOTES

## Be prepared for multiple interviewers

## Initiate or be responsive to small talk



# Interview Follow-Up

## Make note of interviewer name(s)

- Consider asking for their contact information if you don't have contact information already

## After the interview, take some time to reflect on the interview

- Identify key topics of interest, areas of alignment between your skills and the job responsibilities, or anything else notable from the interview

## Follow up with a 'thank you' email within 24 hours

- This will help to set you apart from other applicants, and provides an appropriate space to share additional information
- This should be sent to individual contacts, if possible
- If individual emails aren't available, you can send the note to the interview scheduler for forwarding on the team

# Final Tips:

## Acknowledge & Overcome Nerves

### Be confident

- They contacted you after all

### Be yourself

- Trying to be something you're not will add to your stress and mislead employers

### Be prepared for tough questions

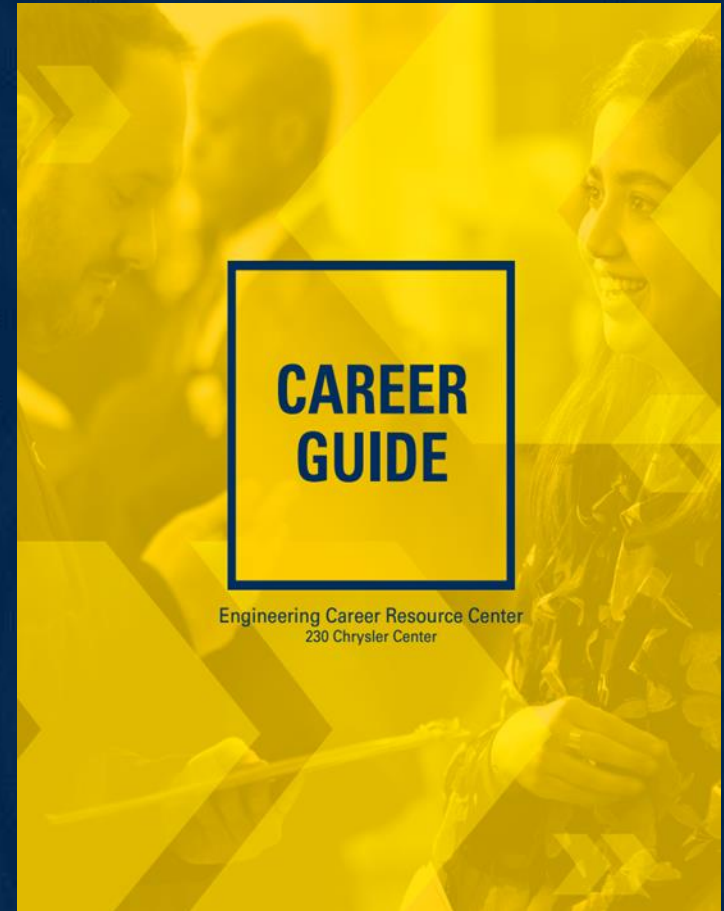
### Be ready by doing research

### PRACTICE!



# Be Sure to Practice!

- Review & practice responses to common interview questions
  - Sample questions, arranged by theme, are available within **Engineering Careers, by 12twenty**
- Practice your responses with a friend
- Schedule a Mock Interview appointment with an ECRC Advisor
- Submit a recorded Mock Interview response for review by an ECRC Advisor
  - <https://umich.instructure.com/courses/529324>



# Networking Basics

Slides from: Engineering Career Resource Center  
Presented by: David Wentzloff, Sept 6, 2024

# Networking Unpacked

- What is networking?
- Why is networking important?
- How is networking done?
  - In-person and Virtual



# What is Networking?

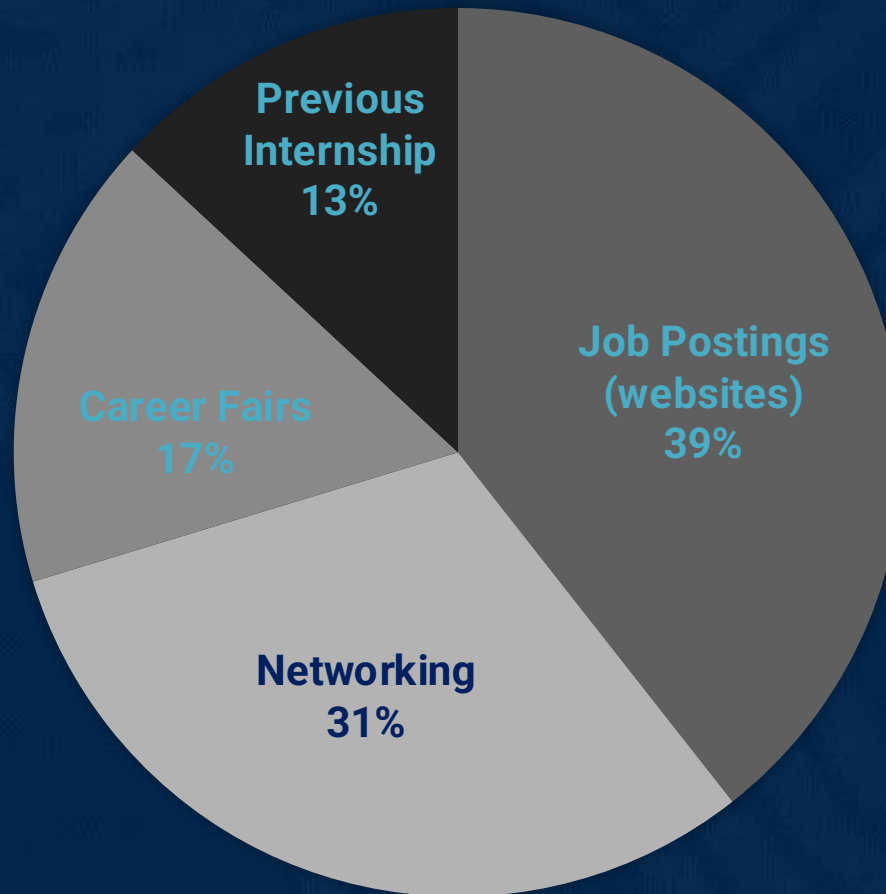
The development and cultivation of relationships that provide you with information, advice, and further contacts.



In its simplest form, networking is building connections to other people.

# Why is Networking Important?

## HOW MICHIGAN ENGINEERS FOUND FULL-TIME JOBS



Source: 2021 – 2022 First Destination Survey. 1,128 respondents answered this question



# Foundational Principle of Networking: Context Matters

- **‘Networking’ Events**
  - Minimal “small talk” will likely suffice
  - Discuss each person’s skills, experiences, professional interests
- **Information Session or Technical Talk**
  - You will likely discuss the presenter’s topic or company
- **Conferences**
  - Discuss your conference experience (i.e. keynote, session, posters)
- **Informational Interview/Coffee Meet-up**
  - “Small talk” will occur to build rapport
  - Find common subject(s) of interest for prolonged conversation

# Impromptu Networking:

Take advantage of opportunities to build relationships as they arise

## *Examples:*

- A colleague invites you to join them for coffee
- You sit next to someone at a conference or symposium
- Engage a classmate before class starts

# Proactive Networking: In-Person

Seek out opportunities to build relationships with people in an industry or field that you want to learn more about

- You make these opportunities happen!

Speak to family, friends, and colleagues about your interests & goals

- You are likely already doing this!
- Use normal communication style
- Expand your definition of friends & colleagues

# Proactive Networking: Preparation

**The Elevator Pitch** - Necessary for both impromptu and proactive networking

Short introduction of who you are and what you want to discuss.

- Name & Education
- Relevant experience/strength/interest
- Why you are talking to them

# Sample Pitch 1: Career Event

Hi, I'm Anne Arbor. I'm graduating in May with a bachelors degree in Civil Engineering, and I am interested in a full-time engineering position with Goblue Construction.

I currently serve as the UM Steel Bridge Team's Construction Captain and Business Lead. I am also an officer for the UM chapter of the American Society of Civil Engineers, where I manage our recruiting and retention efforts.

I'm hoping to apply my leadership and project management skills to the project engineer position at Goblue Construction. Can you tell me more about this opportunity?



# Sample Pitch 2: Non-Career Event

Hello, my name is Mitch Igan, and I am a first year graduate student studying industrial and operations engineering at the University of Michigan.

I'm currently studying theories of group dynamics and human motivation and the impacts on organizational performance.

How about you? What's your background and what do you do?

# Sample Pitch 3: Coffee Meet-up

Hi, I'm David Wentzloff. I'm a professor in Electrical Engineering at UofM.

This Fall I am teaching a class on Engineering Professionalism. This is a seminar-style class that all EECS seniors take which covers several topics to prepare them for starting their professional careers.

One of the topics we cover is preparation for interviewing. Given your extensive experience in recruiting, would you be interested in giving a lecture on this topic?

# Closing Tips & Reminders

- Don't wait until you need something to start networking
- You are just talking to a person
- Remember the context / setting
- Follow through on your commitments
- Have an answer to the question:  
“How can I help?”

# Networking Resources

- **ECRC's Guide to Networking**
  - <https://engin-umich.12twenty.com/Login> -> Resource Library -> Networking -> Networking Guide
- **Engineering Career Guide**
  - <http://career.engin.umich.edu/careerguide>
- **University of Michigan Alumni Association**
  - <https://alumni.umich.edu/career/>
- **LinkedIn Groups:**
  - Michigan Engineering Alumni - OFFICIAL GROUP
  - Official Group: Alumni Association of the University of Michigan
- **Dalton, S. (2012). *The 2-hour job search: Using technology to get the right job faster*. Berkeley: Ten Speed Press.**

# Cover Letter Basics



# The Cover Letter

Amy Gallo, “How to Write a Cover Letter,” HBR, 2020

Should I include a cover letter? **YES!**

What should it include?

- Do your research
  - About the company, the position, the hiring manager, the company leadership
  - Company website, LinkedIn profiles, Twitter feeds...



# The Cover Letter

Amy Gallo, “How to Write a Cover Letter,” HBR, 2020

Should I include a cover letter? **YES!**

What should it include?

- Do your research
- Focus the letter on the future
  - The resume is meant to look back



# The Cover Letter

Amy Gallo, “How to Write a Cover Letter,” HBR, 2020

Should I include a cover letter? **YES!**

What should it include?

- Do your research
- Focus the letter on the future
- Open strong
  - Do: Start with a punchline. Why the job is exciting and what you bring to the table
  - Don’t: “I’m applying for X job that I saw in Y place”



# The Cover Letter

Amy Gallo, “How to Write a Cover Letter,” HBR, 2020

Should I include a cover letter? **YES!**

What should it include?

- Do your research
- Focus the letter on the future
- Open strong
- Emphasize your personal value
  - Draw on the company research you did
  - Provide evidence of things that set you apart



# The Cover Letter

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Should I include a cover letter? **YES!**

What should it include?

- Do your research
- Focus the letter on the future
- Open strong
- Emphasize your personal value
- Watch the tone
  - Be authentic. Don’t go overboard on flattery or trying to be funny





# The Cover Letter

Amy Gallo, “How to Write a Cover Letter,” HBR, 2020

Should I include a cover letter? **YES!**

What should it include?

- Do your research
- Focus the letter on the future
- Open strong
- Emphasize your personal value
- Watch the tone
- Keep it short
  - Someone should be able to read it at-a-glance
  - Use **highlighting** to emphasize points



# Cover Letter DOs and DON'Ts

## Do:

- Have a strong opening statement that makes clear why you want the job and what you bring to the table.
- Be succinct — a hiring manager should be able to read your letter at-a-glance.
- Share an accomplishment that shows you can address the challenges the employer is facing.

## Don't:

- Try to be funny — too often it falls flat.
- Send a generic cover letter — customize each one for the specific job.
- Go overboard with flattery — be professional and mature.



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# **Next Lecture: Startups with Doug Neal, eLab Ventures**

Quiz

Attendance: 10 (UM's AP Poll Rank)